



Jio's 5G plans

Mukesh Ambani, told President Donald Trump that planned Jio 5G networks will have no Chinese component. <https://digit.in/mar20-61>



Amazon bans 1mn COVID-19 products

Amazon has banned over one million coronavirus products with inaccurate health claims. <https://digit.in/mar20-62>

tech

REVIEWS

D-Link DIR-1360 EXO AC1300 Wireless Router

Simple and extensible

D-Link came out with the Exo series of routers in 2016. In 2019, they came out with the new EXO series with support for mesh networking along with baked-in security suite in partnership with McAfee. Then there's also Google Assistant and Alexa support. The DIR-1360 is the baseline model in this new Exo series since it starts off at AC1300 and goes all the way to AC3000. Out of the five models, we have the AC1300, AC1900 and AC2600 routers available in India.

Features

The UI of the DIR-1360 is better than the more budget oriented routers that D-Link has. The common features are easily accessible and simple enough for most people to use.

Setting up the router is fairly simple. If you're comfortable using a wired client then there's nothing like it but if you want to make do with an app, then there's the D-Link Wi-Fi app which allows you to set up and manage the DIR-1360. Even configuring extenders so as to set up the mesh-networking feature, is simple. It even has support for Google Assistant and Amazon Alexa voice commands. With the DIR-1360, we only had four commands available which allowed us to turn the Guest Wi-Fi on or off, ask for the password of the same, reboot the router and upgrade the firmware. With just four commands, it's not much but these four commands are the most common ones. However, for enthusiasts or power-users this is not even hitting the bare minimum.

Coming to the McAfee protection feature, you need to get a separate app called D-Link defend which has a more polished UI. This is where you can use Amazon Alexa to control the features.



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It's odd that Google Assistant isn't featured here. D-Link defend allows you to set up parental control features such as setting up profiles for kids at home, mapping their devices to their profiles and then re-

stricting their access to certain websites and even limiting their time on the Internet. We tried out the feature by following all the steps and adding a few sites to the custom blacklist. Unfortunately, the feature did not block us from visiting the sites that we had blacklisted. So, it seems to be broken. Upon glancing through the reviews on the Google Play Store for D-Link defend, you can see that a lot of people have been facing similar issues.

Build Quality

The DIR-1360 has a simplistic design with the dome-shaped top with indicator LEDs arranged in a vertical strip. There are four adjustable antennas that stick out from the sides with two on each side. While the orientation of the antennas are adjustable, they are not detachable. Ventilation slits are present on all faces of the router. There's one USB 3.0 port and the rear has all the ethernet ports as well as the buttons for WPS, power and resetting the router. The Ethernet contacts are not gold-plated.

On the inside, we see a very thick PCB with all the antenna cables soldered

onto the PCB. The DIR-1360 uses a MediaTek MT7621AT, which is a dual-core 32-bit MIPS CPU clocked at 880 MHz. It's paired with a MediaTek MT7615DN which is an 802.11ac Wave2 MU-MIMO that's set to handle the radios. Overall, the configuration can handle 2x2+2x2 meaning that the 2.4 GHz band and the 5 GHz band can work simultaneously. Since the latter is a low-power SoC, we don't see any heatsinks on it whereas the MT7621AT has a ceramic heatsink.

At 372 grams, the DIR-1360 is just heavy enough to remain stable and doesn't need any additional weights to hold it down. Usually, aluminium plates are used to weigh the router down but it doesn't seem warranted in the case of this router.

Performance

We ran our usual set of bandwidth tests and scored 238 Mbps downlink on the 5 GHz band and around 198 Mbps on the uplink. On the 2.4 GHz band, the uplink was around 76 Mbps and downlink was around 88 Mbps. The USB 3.0 to LAN transfer speeds were 14 MBps on a USB 3.0 flash drive. We tried connecting a USB 3.2 Gen2 external SSD to the router but the router would not recognise the device so we couldn't even hit the maximum possible speeds on the USB port.

Verdict

D-Link is certainly keeping up with the times and having a router that has mesh capabilities is certainly a consumer-friendly move. The performance of the router is at par but there are a few teething issues with the accompanying apps as well as with the USB port. The parental control feature not working properly was a disappointment but hopefully all these issues can be resolved with firmware and app updates. Overall, this is a pretty decent router.

—Mithun Mohandas

SPECIFICATIONS

MODEL: DIR-1360 | WI-FI: 802.11ac | LAN: 4x10/100/1000 Gbit | WAN: 10/100/1000 Gbit | SOC: MT7621AT | WLAN: MT7615DN | DIMENSIONS: 20.2 x 14.4 x 50.8 cms | WEIGHT: 372 gm | WARRANTY: 3 - years.

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